BARBARA POPPE | A CHICO CONVERSATION

Background, relevant perspectives, and conversation context | Thursday, October 15, 2026, 10:00 a.m. Pacific | Zoom

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Who is Barbara Poppe?

Barbara Poppe is a nationally recognized leader in efforts to prevent and end homelessness. She served as Executive Director of the U.S. Interagency Council on Homelessness (USICH) from 2009 to 2014 under President Barack Obama. Before federal service, she led the Community Shelter Board in Columbus, Ohio (1995-2009). She later founded Barbara Poppe and Associates to work with communities on collaborative, measurable solutions to homelessness. [1, 2]

Highlights of her federal leadership

2010 ... Opening Doors: During her tenure, USICH launched the first comprehensive federal strategic plan to prevent and end homelessness, coordinating a council of **19 federal agencies** with state, local, nonprofit, and private partners. [1, 3]

A different measure of success: The plan sought to move beyond simply responding to crises, emphasizing stable and affordable housing, permanent supportive housing, prevention, economic security, and cross-agency accountability. [3]

Documented progress, not a claim that the crisis was solved: USICH reported at her departure in 2014 that homelessness had declined 6% overall since implementation, including 24% among veterans and 16% in chronic homelessness. These are historical agency-reported figures, not proof that any single official or program caused the changes. [2]

In her own words ... particularly relevant to Chico

> *"Homelessness is a choice, but it's the policy choice that we've made. It's not the choice of any of the individuals."*

Barbara Poppe, speaking with Mark Horvath on *Homeless Unfiltered*, Invisible People. [4]

> *"We know how to house every single person."*

Barbara Poppe, same conversation; she then emphasizes that action is a matter of choices and priorities. [4]

These remarks invite a critical question: are public decisions reducing the causes of homelessness, or making the experience of being unhoused more punishable?

Enforcement versus solutions

In the Invisible People interview, Poppe and Horvath discuss criminalization, harmful public narratives, and the importance of listening to people with lived experience. Her work underscores an alternative to treating homelessness primarily as a police or code-enforcement problem: evaluate whether the community is creating viable routes to safe, stable housing. [4, 5]

Why this matters in Chico right now

Chico is considering revisions to camping and public-space enforcement as the *Warren v. City of Chico* settlement approaches its January 2027 expiration. Local advocates are asking for lawful, lower-barrier alternatives for people who cannot access or remain in existing shelters, alongside actual affordable housing production. The goal of this conversation is to learn how to advance practical, non-criminalizing responses while building a broader community coalition.

A closing thought from her USICH chapter

When Poppe announced her departure in 2014, she emphasized the collaborative work of federal agencies, cities, advocates, nonprofits, businesses, and philanthropy. Her message was about shared responsibility and sustained action

... an apt frame for a conversation about turning division into common purpose in Chico. [2]

Suggested conversation focus

1. What approaches can a city take after *Warren* without expanding citations and arrests? **2.** How can we change the public narrative from blame to shared responsibility? **3.** What credible near-term alternatives can coexist with a lasting commitment to affordable housing? **4.** What measures would show whether Chico is actually ending homelessness?

Selected sources and further reading

[1] Funders Together to End Homelessness, Barbara Poppe speaker biography (2022). funderstogether.org/2022_funders_institute_speakers

[2] USICH February 4, 2014 departure announcement (reproduced by People's Advocacy Council). peoplesadvocacycouncil.wordpress.com/2014/02/05/

[3] HUD, *Obama Administration Unveils National Strategic Plan to Prevent and End Homelessness* (June 22, 2010). archives.hud.gov/news/2010/pr10-132.cfm

[4] Invisible People, *Homeless Unfiltered*: Barbara Poppe interviewed by Mark Horvath (transcript supplied for this brief).

[5] Invisible People, *Battle Against Homelessness: Barbara Poppe's Journey From Activism To Advocacy* (2024). invisiblepeople.tv/battle-against-homelessness-barbara-poppes-journey-from-activism-to-advocacy/

Prepared as background for a community conversation; not a statement issued or endorsed by Barbara Poppe.